

INTRODUCTION TO SYNTAX I

Session 4: Clause structure I

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July 30th 2026

OVA 2026

TODAY'S PLAN

- ⦿ Building sentences
- ⦿ Functional categories
- ⦿ Revising our (kinda but not quite yet clausal) structure
- ⦿ Revisiting c-command

FROM PHRASES TO SENTENCES

I What we know so far:

- ⊙ Sentences consist of **constituents** which may be **embedded** within each other;
- ⊙ Constituents bear/assign **θ -roles** + stand in a **selectional relation** with each other;
- ⊙ Constituents have **heads** from which morphosyntactic features are **projected**;
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What we will learn next:

- ⊙ Sentences have a core consisting of the projections of a **lexical category** $\Rightarrow$ the verb phrase (VP).
- ⊙ On top of this core, **functional categories** are built that do project, but do not assign θ -roles.

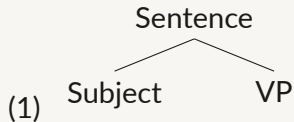
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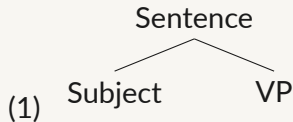
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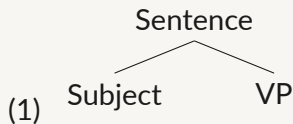
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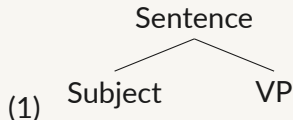
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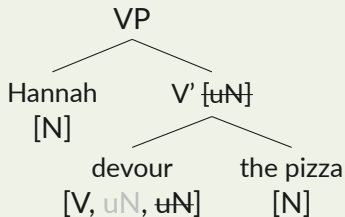


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- ⇒ (1) is at odds with our model based on projection and selection: **there is no head**.
- ◉ (1) would require us to make up a new rule about how the category *Sentence* is introduced, what its properties are, and why building it requires a different approach than combining heads, complements and specifiers.

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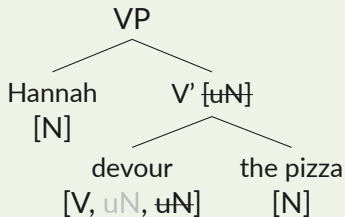
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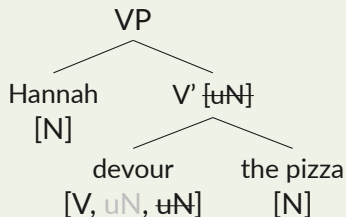
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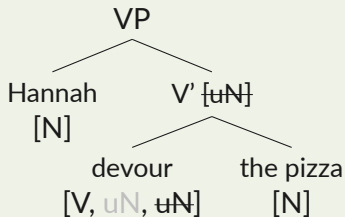
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- ◉ **Hint**: we talked an awful lot about c-selectional features. What **other morphosyntactic** features are there? (recall session 2!)
- ◉ We have yet to introduce **verbal inflection**!

LOCATING THE SOURCE OF INFLECTION

■ Verbal inflection is a property of verbs. Why do we need another head for that?

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- ⊙ Some languages have **auxiliary verbs**: verbs with restricted semantic functions.
- ⊙ **Modal auxiliaries** express obligation, possibility, permission, intension, etc.

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■ Modals are not part of the verbal complex formed by V and its complement:

- (4) a. ...and [seek Ishtar], Gilgamesh may
b. *...and [may seek Ishtar], Gilgamesh does
c. What Gilgamesh may do is [seek Ishtar]¹
d. *What Gilgamesh does is [may seek Ishtar]

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■ In English, expressing tense outside of the VP is optional for emphasis:

- (5) a. Enkidu **did** free animals.
b. Enkidu freed**d** animals.

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- (6) a. Gilgamesh [_{VP}loved Ishtar] and Enkidu **did** [_{VP}], too.
b. The mouse [_{VP}fears the cat] and the dog **does** [_{VP}], too.

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■ Infinitival clauses

- ⊙ Although English verbal inflection is morphologically rather poor, we nevertheless distinguish between **finite** and **infinitival** sentences:

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- ⊙ In the (b)-sentences, there is a **to** that looks like a preposition but precedes verbs³ ⇒ it is **incompatible with** verbs that **agree or carry tense marking**.

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■ Summary of evidence

- ⊙ Modals, emphatic *do* and *to* in infinitival clauses seem to sit **outside of the verbal complex but below the subject**.
- ⊙ Morphological tense marking appears in/depends on this position.

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In Hungarian, modality shows up on the verb when it is (un)marked for present tense, but has to escape to an auxiliary-like expletive stem when the verb is marked for past tense (12).

(12) *Hungarian*

- a. Jani el-men-**ne** a bolt-ba.
Jani PV-go-MOD DET shop-ILL
'Jani would go to the store.'
- b. Jani el-men-**t** vol-**na** a bolt-ba.
Jani PV-go-PST EXPL-MOD DET shop-ILL
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I But wait... where is the subject?

- ⊙ So far, we assumed that the subject is Merged in the specifier of V (recall (2)).
- ⊙ Now, we saw that there seems to be a head, which we labeled T, intervening between the subject and the verbal complex.
- ⊙ We keep the assumption that the subject is **base generated** in the specifier of V.

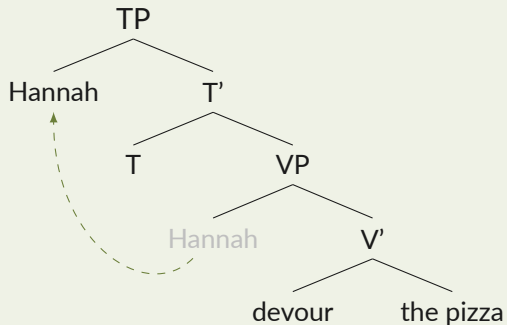
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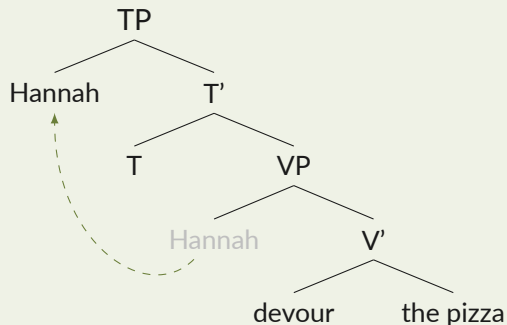
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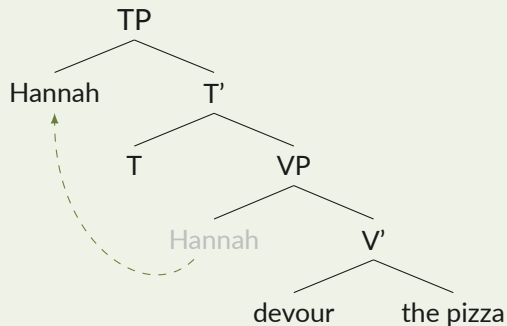
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- ⊙ This structure can account for *Hannah may devour the pizza*, where *devour the pizza* is the complement of the T head *may*, linearized to the right of it; and *Hannah* is the specifier of T linearized to the left of the intermediate projection T'.

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- ◉ It is different from the lexical categories N, V and P we have met so far.
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- b. *Rains.

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TENSE ON VERBS

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- (15) a. T[present] ...V[present]
b. T[past] ...V[past]
c. *T[present] ...V[past]
d. *T[past] ...V[present]

RECAP: C-COMMAND

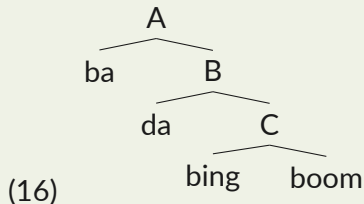
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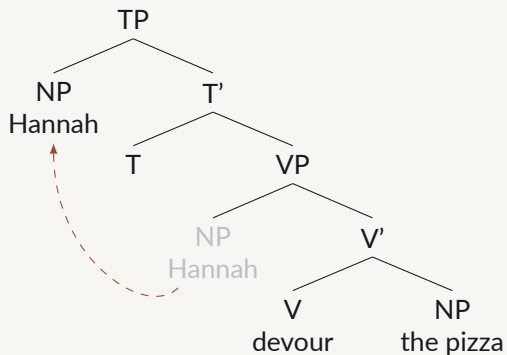
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- ⊙ Can you name the c-command relations in the tree?



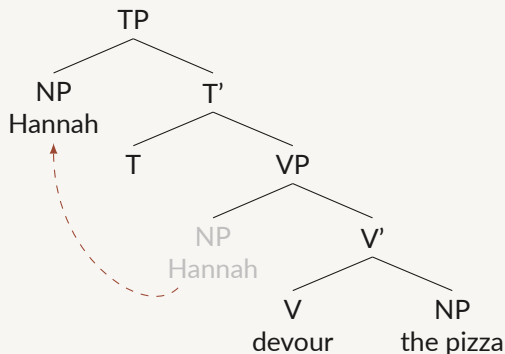
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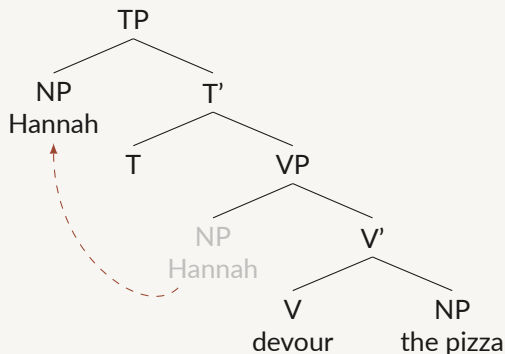
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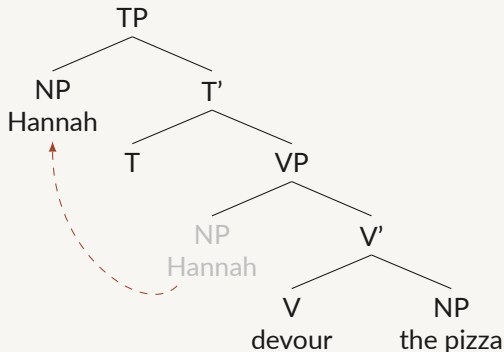
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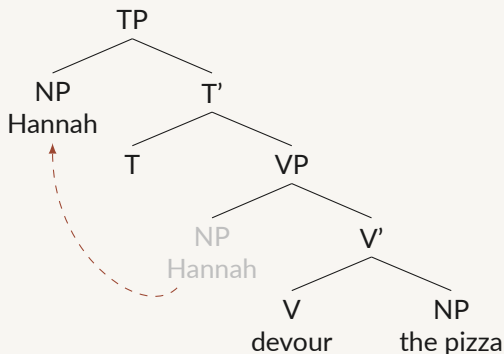
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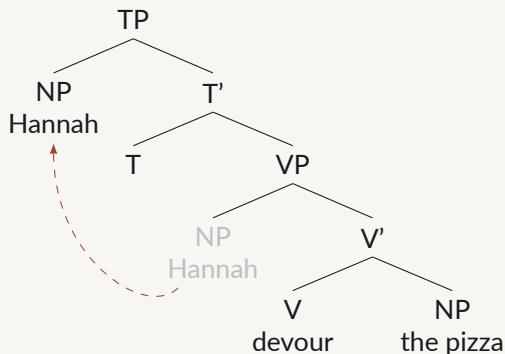
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- ◉ The VP c-commands the T head.
- ◉ The specifier of V (SpecVP, which the NP *Hannah* originates in) c-commands V' and everything dominated by it.
- ◉ V' c-commands SpecVP.

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- ⊙ Sisterhood is actually just the most local version of c-command!
 - ⊙ As such, the **hierarchical relations** that we have seen syntax be sensitive to so far can be **conflated into c-command**.
- ⇒ Selection just happens to be operate on the most local version of c-command.

A NOTE ON THE SUBJECT'S POSITION

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- ⊙ For now, we model this assumption via the EPP-feature on T:⁶
- ⊙ The **closest suitable constituent** moves to the T head to fill the subject position.

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- ⊙ Recall the evidence we saw involving auxiliaries, *do* and infinitival clauses.
- ⊙ For now, we model this assumption via the EPP-feature on T:⁶
- ⊙ The **closest suitable constituent** moves to the T head to fill the subject position.
- ⊙ Only if there is no suitable constituent, like with zero-place predicates, is an expletive spelled out.

- (18) a. Hannah laughed.
b. It rained.
c. *It Hannah laughed.

⁶This is likely one of the trickiest parts of basic syntactic theory, not because the empirical facts are controversial, but how to best capture them in the formal model is. I simplify *a lot* here.

A NOTE ON THE SUBJECT'S POSITION

- **Movement is the most economical solution to satisfy the EPP feature on (English) T:**
 - ⊙ C-selectional features are checked locally, but the EPP feature triggers movement.
 - ⇒ If there is a suitable constituent present in the structure, it will move to SpecTP.

A NOTE ON THE SUBJECT'S POSITION

- **Movement is the most economical solution to satisfy the EPP feature on (English) T:**
 - ⊙ C-selectional features are checked locally, but the EPP feature triggers movement.
 - ⇒ If there is a suitable constituent present in the structure, it will move to SpecTP.
- **In languages with null subjects, free word order and postverbal subjects:**
 - ⊙ We have **much fewer reasons to assume subject movement to SpecTP.**
 - ⊙ **T is projected nonetheless:** recall its primary purpose for tense and inflection.
- **Next week, you will learn more about these cross-linguistic nuances.**

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■ What about interrogatives? And embedded sentences?

The model we have so far can only generate simple declarative sentences.

EMBEDDED CLAUSES

- (19) a. I think **that** it will rain.
b. I wonder **whether** it will rain.
c. I think **that** Hannah will devour the pizza.
d. I wonder **whether** Hannah will devour the pizza.

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■ The elements in bold are called complementizers.

- ⊙ Where do these complementizers stand relative to the other elements of the sentence?
- ⊙ What does this imply for the structure we have so far?

WHAT AWAITS US TOMORROW

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- (20) a. I wonder **whether** she will sleep.
b. **Whether** she will sleep, I wonder.
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WHAT AWAITS US TOMORROW

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■ **Complementizers are at the very top of the embedded clause!**

⇒ Our tree will yet again have to grow.

Ask away!

■ Pseudoclefting is another constituency test:

- ⊙ It is similar to clefting, which we saw in session 1, except that it uses a wh-word matching the constituent's category and features, and places the constituent we are testing at the very end rather than the beginning of the sentence.
- ⊙ Applied to our example from session 1:

(21) *Sentence (a), clefting (b) and pseudoclefting (c)*

- The mouse that stole the cheese was hiding from the cat **in the cabinet**.
- It was **in the cabinet** that the mouse that stole the cheese was hiding from the cat.
- Where** the mouse that stole the cheese was hiding from the cat was **in the cabinet**.

APPENDIX: THETA ROLES ASSIGNED BY N AND P

(22) *Verbs (a, c) vs. deverbal nouns (b,d)*

- a. Brecht adapted Villon.
- b. Brecht's adaptation of Villon
- c. They destroyed the city.
- d. the destruction of the city

Brecht = agent; Villon = theme

Brecht = agent; Villon = theme

they = agent; city = patient

city = theme

(23) *Prepositions*

- a. He went to the store.
- b. The mouse is hiding in the cabinet.
- c. She hit the man with a stick.

store = goal

cabinet = location

stick = instrument